Vietnamese Art Marketplace

Product Requirements Document

Version 3.0 | March 2026 | Quynh & Julius

v3.0 update: Revised business model — buyers fund a platform that serves artists for free. Technology eliminates middlemen costs, reinvesting the margin into artist welfare, grants, and growth programs. Artists who sell well unlock progressively more support.

1. Overview & Purpose

1.1 Problem Statement

Vietnam's art market is at an inflection point. Despite a thriving contemporary art scene, the infrastructure for buying and selling work remains fragmented and underdeveloped. Artists without gallery representation have no viable direct-to-buyer channel. Traditional galleries take 40–60% commission and provide inconsistent support. The general public perceives original art as expensive and inaccessible, despite the availability of affordable work from emerging talent.

There is no platform in Vietnam that simultaneously: (a) enables direct artist-to-buyer sales at accessible price points, (b) integrates the full art events calendar into a shopping experience, (c) provides comprehensive backend support to artists — not as a revenue line, but as the core value proposition.

1.2 Core Model — Buyers Fund the Artist Ecosystem

> *The fundamental insight: galleries charge artists 40–60%. We use technology to eliminate that overhead and pass the savings to artists — not as zero commission, but as real services (documentation, marketing, logistics, conservation, grants, residencies). Buyers pay a buyer's premium that funds this ecosystem. Artists focus on creating. The platform funds their growth.*

This is not just a marketplace. It is a cultural infrastructure platform built around artist welfare. The business model is inspired by how public arts councils and private foundations work — but made sustainable through commerce rather than charity.

1.3 Market Context

Vietnam is emerging as a serious contemporary art hub in Southeast Asia. The global online fine art market was valued at $12.1B in 2024, growing at 12.1% CAGR. Asia-Pacific was the largest regional art market in 2024, with Asian buyers accounting for 35% of global art sales. However, Vietnamese artists have no domestic digital infrastructure to capture this demand — they are accessed almost entirely through foreign platforms built for foreign buyers.

The Vietnamese government (Ministry of Culture) has recently published policy recommendations on enforcing visual art copyright and developing a technology roadmap for the cultural industries — signaling that regulatory support for digital art platforms is improving.

1.4 Vision

> *"Create an accessible art marketplace that empowers emerging Vietnamese artists to sell their work directly while building a vibrant art community."*

1.5 Mission

Make art accessible to the general public while providing comprehensive, free support for artists who lack gallery representation — enabling artists to earn a living and continue creating without financial or logistical burden.

1.6 Document Scope

In scope	Web platform MVP, marketplace features, art events hub, artist support tiers, revised business model, competitive analysis
Out of scope	Mobile apps (future), physical showroom, offline logistics execution
Version	v3.0 — revised business model: buyer-funded artist welfare ecosystem
Audience	Quynh, Julius, and future engineering / design collaborators

2. Competitive Analysis

2.1 Existing Vietnamese Platforms

Platform	Format	Target Audience	Price Range	Gap / Our Opportunity
Le Auction House(leauctions.vn)	Online auction	Established collectors, heritage art buyers	High — Indochina & resistance era art	Emerging artists excluded; no fixed-price; no events; no artist support
Chon Auction House(Facebook)	Social commerce auction	Casual buyers, mid-market collectors	Mid range	No proper storefront; no discoverability outside Facebook; informal
Hoa Ta Gallery(gallery.hoata.art)	Small online gallery	Photography & calligraphy fans	Accessible	Single gallery; contact via Zalo; not a marketplace
Nguyen Art Gallery	Gallery + intl. shipping	International buyers; established artists	Mid to high	Established artists only; no open marketplace; no domestic buyer UX
Manzi Art Space(Hanoi, offline)	Physical venue + informal sales	Local arts community	Low to mid	Offline only — currently the strongest domestic sales channel; ideal partner

2.2 Competitive Positioning

Unique position: the only platform in Vietnam combining (1) open marketplace with accessible pricing, (2) full art events hub with purchase integration, (3) bilingual Vietnamese-first UX, and (4) free artist support services funded by buyer premiums — not artist fees. No existing player even attempts the artist welfare dimension.

2.3 Key Partnership Targets

- Manzi Art Space — currently the strongest domestic sales channel; cross-listing and events partner
- The Outpost Art Organisation — Vietnam's first private contemporary art museum; curated content and residency partner
- Chon Auction House — their Facebook buyer pool is a migration target for a more professional experience
- International media: ArtReview Asia, Artsper — for international buyer pipeline

3. Goals & Success Metrics

3.1 Business Goals

- Validate that Vietnamese buyers will purchase original art online and accept a buyer's premium
- Build an initial roster of active artist sellers — target 20+ by month 3
- Establish the platform as the most artist-friendly sales channel in Vietnam
- Generate enough buyer-premium revenue to fund at least 2 artist support grants by month 12
- Attract international buyers — capturing demand currently served only by foreign platforms

3.2 Success Metrics

Metric	Target (3 months)	Target (12 months)
Artist sign-ups	20	100
Artwork listings	50	500
Completed sales	5	100
Average transaction value (USD)	$80	$150
Monthly unique visitors	500	5,000
Event listings posted	10	60
Artist satisfaction (NPS)	>= 30	>= 60
Buyer repeat purchase rate	—	20%
International buyer share	5%	20%
Artists receiving support tier 2+	0	15
Grants / residencies awarded	0	2

4. Target Users & Personas

4.1 Primary Persona — The Domestic Buyer

Name	Linh, 28, Marketing Manager — Ho Chi Minh City
Goals	Find unique home decor; own something meaningful and original; support Vietnamese artists
Pain points	Art feels expensive and intimidating; doesn't know where to look; uncertain about authenticity
Behavior	Browses Instagram for aesthetics; attends art events; pays via bank transfer or MoMo
Willingness to pay	1–10M VND (~$40–$400 USD); comfortable with a small buyer's premium if it supports artists

4.2 Secondary Persona — The International Buyer

Name	Anna, 35, Expat or Cultural Tourist in Hanoi / HCMC
Goals	Find authentic Vietnamese art; support local artists; get professional international shipping
Pain points	No trusted Vietnamese platform in English; shipping concerns; no card payment options
Behavior	Researches online; has experience on Saatchi or Artsper; expects professional UX
Willingness to pay	$100–$600 USD; expects card payment, certificate of authenticity, and proper packaging

4.3 The Artist

Name	Minh, 26, Emerging Painter — Hanoi
Goals	Sell work without gallery representation; get documentation, logistics, and marketing help; build an online following
Pain points	Gallery commissions 40–60%; shows do not convert; no business infrastructure; no time to handle admin
Key insight	Minh does not need a cheaper gallery. He needs someone to handle everything that is not painting.
Revenue goal	Earn enough to paint full-time — currently supplementing income with commercial work

5. Business Model

5.1 The Core Principle: Buyers Fund Artists

Traditional galleries charge artists 40–60% commission. This platform inverts the model: artists list and sell with zero or near-zero platform fees. Instead, buyers pay a buyer's premium on top of the artist's listed price. This premium, combined with platform revenue from events and optional buyer-side services, funds the artist support ecosystem.

Technology makes this viable. Unlike a gallery, we have no physical space overhead, no curatorial staff overhead per artist, and no sales team to pay per transaction. The margin from eliminated middlemen is redirected to artist welfare — documentation, marketing, logistics, conservation, and eventually grants and residencies.

5.2 Revenue Streams

Revenue Stream	Who Pays	Rate / Model	Phase
Buyer's premium	Buyer	10–15% on top of artist's price (displayed transparently at checkout)	Phase 1
Platform subscription (optional)	Buyer	Premium membership: saved searches, early access, collector perks	Phase 2
Event promotion	Event organizers	Paid featured placement in the events hub	Phase 1
International shipping margin	Buyer	Small margin on shipping logistics coordination	Phase 2
Corporate / institutional art advisory	Companies, hotels, offices	Curated art procurement service for interior projects	Phase 3
Grants and residency program sponsorship	Cultural institutions, brands	Sponsors fund the artist welfare pool in exchange for naming rights	Phase 2

5.3 What Artists Pay: Nothing (or Almost Nothing)

> *Artists list for free. Artists sell and keep the full listed price. The platform makes money from buyers, not artists. This is the single most important differentiating message when recruiting artists away from galleries and informal channels.*

The only potential artist-side fee: a small optional fee for expedited support service requests (e.g. rush professional photography). Even this is waived for artists in higher support tiers.

5.4 Artist Support Tiers — Welfare Funded by Buyer Premiums

As buyer-premium revenue grows, it is reinvested into artist support. Artists unlock higher tiers based on their sales performance on the platform — creating a flywheel: more sales → more support → better work → more sales.

Tier	Trigger	Services Unlocked	Cost to Artist
Starter	Any verified artist	Profile page, unlimited listings, basic community access	**Free**
Rising	3+ sales OR 1M+ VND sold	Professional photo session (1x/yr), social media feature, priority listing	**Free**
Established	10+ sales OR 10M+ VND sold	All Rising perks + artwork documentation archive, conservation consultation, logistics support for shows	**Free**
Flagship	Top 10% of sellers by revenue	All Established perks + funded residency application support, press release service, international shipping coordination, curator introduction	**Free**
Grant eligible	Any tier — applied by platform or self-nominated	Platform-funded grant for a specific project, equipment, or residency — no strings attached	**Free**

5.5 The Grant and Residency Program

As the platform matures and buyer-premium revenue grows, a portion is ring-fenced for an artist welfare fund. This fund operates like a micro-grant program:

- Project grants: fund a specific body of work, exhibition, or equipment purchase
- Residency support: subsidize international residency application fees, travel, or documentation
- Scholarship access: connect artists with external scholarships and grant opportunities, with platform support to apply

- Institutional partnerships: negotiate access to international residency programs (ISCP New York, Tokyo Arts and Space, etc.) for top-performing platform artists

Sponsorship model: cultural brands, hotels, and corporations who want to associate with Vietnamese art can sponsor the welfare fund in exchange for naming rights (e.g. "The [Brand] Artist Grant, supported by [Platform]"). This reduces the revenue burden on buyer premiums alone.

5.6 Pricing Transparency

Buyers see the full price breakdown at checkout: Artist price (100%) + Platform support fee (buyer's premium, ~10–15%) = Total. This transparency builds trust and turns the buyer's premium into a statement of values — you are not just buying art, you are supporting the artist ecosystem.

6. Feature Requirements

6.1 Feature Priority Overview

Feature / Requirement	Priority	Status
User registration and profiles (artist + buyer)	**P0**	Phase 1
Artwork listing and management (CRUD)	**P0**	Phase 1
Marketplace browse and search	**P0**	Phase 1
Fixed-price purchase flow with buyer's premium display	**P0**	Phase 1
Admin listing review and approval queue	**P0**	Phase 1
Artist support tier tracking (internal)	**P0**	Phase 1
Art events hub — listing and discovery	P1	Phase 1
Artist portfolio pages	P1	Phase 1
Artist tier dashboard (visible to artist)	P1	Phase 2
Auction / bidding format	P1	Phase 2
Interactive map and event route planning	P1	Phase 2
Grant application portal	P2	Phase 2
Performance art bookings	P2	Phase 2
International shipping calculator	P2	Phase 2
Residency program integration	P2	Phase 3
Corporate art advisory module	P2	Phase 3

6.2 Marketplace Core

Artwork Listings

Artists independently list artworks. Required fields:

- Title, description, medium, dimensions, year created
- Price — artist's price (the buyer's premium is added automatically at checkout; not set by artist)
- Up to 8 high-resolution images per listing
- Availability: Available / Sold / Reserved
- Category: Painting, Sculpture, Mixed Media, Photography, Video Art, Installation

Checkout and Pricing Display

- Artist price shown on listing page — clean and simple
- At checkout: line-item breakdown showing Artist Price + Support Fee (buyer's premium) = Total
- Brief tooltip or info box: 'The support fee funds free services for Vietnamese artists: documentation, marketing, grants, and residencies'
- Phase 1: Manual bank transfer; Phase 2: MoMo, VNPay (domestic) + Stripe (international)

6.3 Art Events Hub

- Any verified user can submit an event: Exhibition, Performance, Workshop, Auction, Talk
- Calendar and list views; filter by city, type, date, free vs. paid
- Event page links directly to participating artists' listed artworks for purchase
- Map and route planner — Phase 2

6.4 Artist Profile and Tier System

- Artist profile: bio, portrait, location, social links, support tier badge
- Portfolio: all active and sold listings; sold prices optionally hidden
- Follow system: buyers follow artists, receive new listing notifications
- Artist dashboard: sales stats, tier progress bar, next tier unlock requirements, available support services
- Admin can manually elevate or adjust tier (e.g. for an artist with strong critical reception but fewer sales)

6.5 Artist Support Services — Delivered by Platform

These are not self-serve tools. They are platform-provided services, delivered by the team (or trusted partners) and unlocked based on tier:

- **Professional photography: Platform coordinates a photographer session for the artist's studio or works**
  - Unlocks at: Rising tier
  - Frequency: 1 session per year
- **Artwork documentation and archiving: Digital catalogue with standardized metadata, condition notes, provenance**
  - Unlocks at: Established tier
- **Conservation consultation: Introduction to a vetted conservator; basic advice on storage and care**
  - Unlocks at: Established tier
- **Logistics support: Platform coordinates domestic artwork pickup, packaging, and delivery for sales**
  - Unlocks at: Rising tier (assisted); Established tier (fully coordinated)

- **Marketing and press: Social media feature post, press release drafting, newsletter inclusion**
  - Unlocks at: Rising tier
- **Grant application support: Platform team helps identify and apply for external grants and residencies**
  - Unlocks at: Flagship tier
- **Platform-funded micro-grant: Direct financial grant for a specific project, equipment, or travel**
  - Unlocks at: Grant eligible (applied or nominated — any tier)

7. User Stories

7.1 Artist Stories

- As an artist, I can register and create a profile so buyers can discover me and my work.
- As an artist, I can list artwork with photos and my own price, knowing the platform adds its fee on the buyer side.
- As an artist, I can see my current support tier and what I need to sell to unlock the next level.
- As an artist at Rising tier, I can book a professional photography session through the platform.
- As an artist at Established tier, I can get logistics support for shipping a sold work to a buyer.
- As an artist at Flagship tier, I can get help applying for an international residency program.
- As any artist, I can be nominated for or apply for a platform micro-grant for a specific project.
- As an artist, I can submit an upcoming event to the events hub so buyers can find me in person.

7.2 Buyer Stories

- As a buyer, I can browse artworks by category and price without creating an account.
- As a buyer, I can see exactly how my purchase is broken down: artist price + support fee at checkout.
- As a buyer, I understand that the support fee funds free services, grants, and residencies for Vietnamese artists.
- As a buyer, I can follow an artist and be notified when they list new work.
- As a buyer, I can discover upcoming art events in my city and plan a multi-venue route.
- As an international buyer, I can browse in English, pay by card, and get international shipping coordination.

7.3 Admin Stories

- As an admin, I can review and approve artist registrations and listings.
- As an admin, I can view each artist's tier status and manually adjust if needed.
- As an admin, I can manage the grant pool balance and award grants to eligible artists.
- As an admin, I can configure the buyer's premium percentage and view its contribution to the welfare fund.
- As an admin, I can view platform-wide sales, buyer premium revenue, and welfare fund allocations.

8. Technical Requirements

8.1 Recommended Stack

Frontend	Next.js (React) — SSR for SEO, fast page loads, marketplace discoverability
Backend	Node.js with Next.js API routes — lightweight, JS consistency
Database	PostgreSQL — handles listings, users, orders, tier logic; host on Supabase or Railway
File storage	Cloudinary or AWS S3 — image uploads, WebP optimization
Auth	Supabase Auth or NextAuth.js — email/password and social login
Payments (Phase 1)	Manual bank transfer with admin verification; consider MoMo from day one for domestic UX
Payments (Phase 2)	MoMo + VNPay (domestic) + Stripe (international) — dual payment rail is essential
Search	Postgres full-text (Phase 1); Algolia or Meilisearch (Phase 2)
Maps	Google Maps API — venue pinning and route planning for events hub
Email	Resend or SendGrid — transactional emails for purchases, tier upgrades, grant notifications
Analytics	PostHog — track tier progression, buyer premium conversion, funnel drop-off
Hosting	Vercel + Supabase / Railway — low cost, easy CI/CD

8.2 Tier System Data Model (Key Tables)

The artist support tier system requires the following database logic:

- artists table: tier (enum: starter / rising / established / flagship), total_sales_count, total_revenue_vnd, tier_updated_at
- support_services table: service_type, artist_id, status, scheduled_date, delivered_at, notes
- welfare_fund table: balance_vnd, total_collected (from buyer premiums), total_disbursed
- grants table: artist_id, amount_vnd, purpose, status (nominated / reviewing / approved / disbursed), awarded_at
- Tier upgrade job: runs nightly; checks each artist's sales metrics; auto-promotes tiers; sends notification email on upgrade

8.3 Vietnam-Specific Payment Context

Vietnamese domestic buyers overwhelmingly use local payment methods. MoMo (50M+ users) and VNPay must be integrated by Phase 2. Stripe alone will not serve the domestic buyer

persona. International buyers require Stripe or PayPal. The buyer's premium is calculated and displayed server-side at checkout to prevent manipulation.

8.4 Performance and Security

- Homepage and listing pages load under 3 seconds on 4G mobile in Vietnam
- Images served in WebP with lazy loading; max 200KB per image
- 99.5% uptime during Vietnamese business hours (7AM–11PM ICT)
- HTTPS / TLS 1.2+; bcrypt password hashing; payment data never stored server-side
- Rate limiting on all public endpoints; admin audit log for all tier changes and grant awards

8.5 Internationalization

- Bilingual: Vietnamese (primary) and English (secondary) from launch
- Currency: VND primary, USD secondary with live exchange rate
- All datetimes in ICT (UTC+7) by default

9. Execution Plan

9.1 Phase 1 — Test Website (MVP)

Goals

- Validate that buyers will pay a buyer's premium when framed as artist welfare funding
- Onboard 10–20 founding artists; list 50+ artworks
- Complete 5+ real sales to validate checkout with buyer's premium
- Collect data on buyer's premium acceptance rate and drop-off

Minimum Feature Set to Launch

- Artist registration and profiles
- Artwork listing with artist-set price
- Checkout showing artist price + buyer's premium breakdown
- Manual payment (bank transfer) with admin confirmation
- Basic events listing
- Admin panel: approve listings, track sales, view welfare fund balance
- Internal tier tracking (not yet shown to artists in Phase 1)

9.2 Phase 2 — Activate the Flywheel

- Launch artist tier dashboard — artists can see their tier, progress, and services
- Begin delivering Rising-tier services: photography sessions, logistics support, social features
- Integrate MoMo / VNPay (domestic) and Stripe (international)
- Launch auction / bidding feature
- Add interactive map and route planner to events hub
- Award first platform micro-grant — major PR moment

9.3 Phase 3 — Institutionalize

- Formalize the grant and residency program with named sponsorships
- Launch corporate art advisory service for companies and hotels
- Negotiate international residency partnerships (ISCP, Tokyo Arts and Space, etc.)
- Open physical showroom if traction is validated

9.4 Team and Hiring Plan

Quynh	Content creation, artist relations, Vietnamese-language copy, artist onboarding

Julius (Ju)	Product strategy, PRD, business development, investor and partner proposals
Priority hire: Artist connector	Existing relationships in Vietnamese artist community — this unlocks supply
Priority hire: Art curator	Quality vetting, tier assessment, grant review
Priority hire: Developer	Full-stack or AI-assisted developer to build Phase 1
Later: Logistics coordinator	Domestic shipping, artwork transport, support service delivery
Later: Finance manager	Welfare fund accounting, commission payouts, grant disbursements, tax documentation

10. Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
Buyers resist the buyer's premium or perceive it as hidden fees	**High**	Make it radically transparent at checkout; frame it as 'Artist Support Fee' not 'Platform Fee'; test multiple framings in Phase 1
Artists still prefer informal channels (Facebook, Manzi) over signing up	**High**	Offer zero-commission founding membership + immediate photography session for first 20 sign-ups; partner with Manzi for credibility
Support services are operationally too demanding to deliver at scale	Medium	Phase 1: only track tiers internally; begin delivering Rising tier services in Phase 2 with a small partner network of photographers and logistics providers
Welfare fund revenue insufficient to fund meaningful grants	Medium	Seek corporate / brand sponsorship of the welfare fund in Phase 2; frame as CSR opportunity for Vietnamese brands wanting to associate with culture
Low organic traffic to test site	Medium	Seed events hub content from day one; leverage Quynh's network; partner with Hanoi Grapevine-style channels
Payment friction for domestic buyers	Medium	Phase 1 bank transfer is acceptable for early adopters; MoMo / VNPay are Phase 2 priorities before scale
Copyright and IP enforcement gaps in Vietnam	Low-Medium	Monitor Ministry of Culture policy developments; add basic IP education to artist onboarding

11. Open Questions

The following decisions are outstanding and should be resolved before or during Phase 1:

1. Final platform / brand name — needed before domain registration and visual identity
2. Buyer's premium rate — recommend starting at 12% and testing sensitivity; what rate causes checkout abandonment?
3. Framing of the premium — 'Artist Support Fee'? 'Community Fund'? 'Care Fee'? Test messaging
4. Phase 1 payment — is bank transfer acceptable, or should MoMo be integrated from day one?
5. Grant program structure — how much must accumulate in the welfare fund before awarding the first grant? What is the minimum meaningful grant amount in Vietnam?
6. Manzi partnership — approach before or after launch? A pre-launch endorsement from Manzi would significantly de-risk artist onboarding
7. Launch date — set a specific target to scope Phase 1 work and create team accountability
8. Phase 1 budget — hosting, design tools, photography for first Rising-tier artists, any paid marketing
9. Developer — hire, partner, or build primarily with AI coding tools (Claude Code, Cursor)?

Recommended next step: 2-hour working session to resolve items 1, 2, 3, 6, and 7. These are the most strategically important decisions and directly shape the product, brand, and go-to-market. The rest can be decided in the first week of development.